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Election 2018 - Contests now up to voters in Valley - Congressional race, other decisions on the ballot Tuesday

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Page: 1
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San Fernando Valley voters in Tuesday's general election will get a taste of the national battle between the two major political parties through a hotly contested race between the 25th District's Republican congressman and his Democratic challenger.

Also on the ballot are more local matters, such as tax measures and state and city contests

The 25th Congressional District, which touches the Valley's northern edge, features a highly watched matchup. The race between Democratic challenger Katie Hill and Republican incumbent Steve Knight has come to represent the Democratic Party's bid to flip Republican control of the U.S. House of Representatives.

Knight, 51, is a former member of the Palmdale City Council and the California Legislature. He

served in the Army and the Los Angeles Police Department. Knight is seeking a third term in Congress.

This is the first run for Hill, 31, who previously led PATH, a homeless-services nonprofit. She hopes to benefit from the district's shift away from Republican dominance.

Other congressional races Tuesday include Democratic incumbents facing mostly lesser known Republicans: They include Tony Cardenas defending his northeast Valley 29th District seat against Republican Benito Bernal, an education transportation supervisor; Adam Schiff seeking re-election against Johnny J. Nalbandian, a food industry businessman, in the 28th District, which touches the East Valley; and Julia Brownley seeking to retain her 26th District seat on the Valley's western edge against actor Antonio Sabato Jr. Congressman Brad Sherman, who represents the western swathe of the Valley, is facing a Republican Mark Reed, a rancher and businessman.

The valley's state Assembly races have shaken out into match-ups between Democrats and Republicans, even though California's system advances the top two vote-getters in the June primary, no matter their party affiliation.

This has given Valley voters an option to consider Republican candidates in a state Legislature controlled by Democrats.

That equation is reversed in a highly competitive race on the Valley's northern edge. In the 38th Assembly District, where Democratic and Republican voters are fairly evenly split, Republican incumbent Dante Acosta faces challenger Christy Smith, a Newhall school board member. The two also were rivals in 2016, with Smith coming close to beating Acosta.

Republicans hope to provide alternatives in three other Assembly districts where Democrats are strong. In the 39th District, Ricardo Benitez, a business owner and Republican, is challenging Assemblywoman Luz Rivas, elected in June to finish a term vacated by Raul Bocanegra amid sexual harassment allegations.

College student Justin Clark, a Republican from Calabasas, has his sights on 45th District Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel. He faces a steep battle, as Gabriel has support from local and state political leaders and has already been assigned a leadership role in the Assembly.

Roxanne Beckford Hoge is the Republican challenger in the 46th District, where Assemblyman Adrin Nazarian is

seeking a third two-year term.

Also of interest in the eastern Valley is the race between 44th District Assemblywoman Jacqui Irwin, a Democrat, and Republican challenger Ronda Baldwin-Kennedy, an attorney and mother.

Two Valley Assembly seats held by Democrats are uncontested.

The 43rd District's Laura Friedman, who represents an area that includes Glendale, and the 50th District's Richard Bloom, who represents a portion of the East Valley, have two-year terms guaranteed them.

A number of municipal elections in the Valley feature tax measures and City Council races.

In the city of San Fernando, Measure A asks voters to extend a temporary half-percent sales tax approved in 2013 that raised the city's sales tax to 10 cents on the dollar. With the added tax sunsetting in 2020, city officials are asking voters to keep it going indefinitely in order to pay for "essential city services." If passed, voters would need to put a measure on a ballot to end the tax.

The half-percent sales tax generates about $2.5 million annually. The city's annual budget is just under $20 million.

The half-percent sales tax initially was in response to a city-declared "fiscal emergency," which resulted in layoffs, reductions in employee benefits, the discontinuation of retiree medical benefits for new employees and other budget cuts.

Since 2013, Measure A has brought in $10.78 million. Last year, the tax brought in $2.6 million, according to the city, but with the closure of one of the city's largest retailers, Sam's Club, in January, this year's revenue is anticipated to dip down to $2.4 million.

The city has used the sales tax revenue to whittle away at its general fund deficit from $5.7 million to just under $500,000 million. City officials say they try to use the funds on one-time costs, such as buying police vehicles, upgrading computer networks, and improving medians and parks.

Officials say loss of the funds will mean a "significant gap in revenues" just as the city is getting back on its feet financially. The continued revenue is necessary to strengthen the city's "rainy day" reserves, replace public safety and public works vehicles and equipment, create a buffer for future economic downturns or an unforeseen lawsuit or claims, and pave streets, city officials say. The use of the revenue for city operational costs would be unrestricted.

San Fernando voters also will pick three City Council members to serve four-year terms on the five-member panel. Of the six candidates, three are incumbents. They are Sylvia Ballin, a retired analyst for the Metropolitan Water District, seeking a third term; Antonio G. Lopez, director of an architecture firm, seeking a third term; and Jaime Soto, a college history professor, seeking a second term. The three challengers are Yvonne Mejia Pena, a planning and education commissioner who works in compliance and risk management; Hector Pacheco, an attorney focusing on business and entertainment law; and David Bernal, a union steward and AT&T technician.

Glendale is another city where voters will be considering a sales tax. Measure S proposes to add a three-quarters of a cent sales tax on top of the current 9 1/2 cents tax on the dollar, to pay for city services. The tax is expected to raise about $30 million a year in sales tax revenue.

Measure P in Burbank also calls for a three-quarters of a cent on the dollar sales tax increase. If approved, tax could generate about $20 million a year for police, fire stations, street repairs, parks and recreation and libraries. The city is forecasting a funding shortfall of more than $27 million a year, composed of a $9.5 million operating deficit and $18 million in infrastructure needs.

Three seats on the Calabasas City Council are on the ballot, with four candidates running. They include three

incumbents: David J. Shapiro, the mayor pro tem; James R. Bozajian, a councilman; Mary Sue Maurer, also a member of the council and an environmental educator. Vahid Naziri, an attorney and broker, is making a bid to unseat one of them.

In Agoura Hills, three seats are available, and five candidates are running. They are Chris Anstead, a biotech account executive; Deborah Klein Lopez, a community volunteer; Denis Weber, a council member and banker; Harry Schwarz, a manager and council member; and Jan Gerstel, a business owner.

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